ngspice-46 vs. Spectre — Feature Gap Analysis

Ngspice + OpenVAF Enhancements project

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Contents

ngspice-46 vs. a commercial simulator (Spectre) — feature gap analysis

A capability comparison of the ngspice-46 build in this repository against a Spectre-class commercial simulator, to show where the open-source tool already matches the commercial one and where the gaps are. Grounded in a direct read of the `ngspice-46/src/` tree (analyses, solver, devices, RF, convergence, parallelism), not marketing feature lists.

Legend: ✓ present / on par · ⚠ partial, experimental, or via a workaround · × absent. "Spectre" stands in for the commercial reference (Spectre / SpectreRF / Spectre X / RelXpert feature set).

The one column that matters is ngspice — Spectre has essentially everything, so its column is a baseline of ✓. The point of the table is where ngspice's mark is ⚠ or ×.

> Context: the Verilog-A / OSDI device side is not a gap — thanks to the OpenVAF-reloaded compiler in this repository it is on par with (often ahead of) commercial Verilog-A support. The gaps below are all on the simulator/analysis side.

Core numerics

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Core solver	Sparse LU (KLU) direct solver	✓[1]	✓
Core solver	Legacy Sparse1.3 fallback	✓	✓
Core solver	Parallel / partitioned / GPU linear solve	×	✓
Core solver	Matrix reordering + scaling beyond KLU defaults	⚠	✓
Integration	Trapezoidal + variable-order Gear	✓	✓
Integration	Advanced LTE-based step/order control	⚠	✓
Convergence	gmin stepping + source stepping homotopy	✓	✓
Convergence	Pseudo-transient / dynamic-gmin continuation	⚠	✓
Convergence	Damped / trust-region (globalized) Newton	⚠	✓
Convergence	Coordinated accuracy presets (`errpreset`)	✓	✓

The two convergence ⚠ rows: ngspice's DC path is not naked — it has per-device junction limiting (30 device families), an optional `nodedamping` step clamp, and a multi-stage homotopy cascade (`dynamic_gmin` → `new_gmin` → `spice3_gmin` → source stepping). What it lacks vs. commercial tools is a principled *globalized Newton (residual-based trust-region / Armijo) and a classic pseudo-transient (Ẋ-embedded) continuation. Enhancement-111 adds the former: `.option linesearch`, an Armijo backtracking line search on a new KCL-residual merit $\|F\|=\|G\cdot x-b\|$ (result-neutral, off by default) — see the implementation write-up. Enhancement-112 then extended it to the KLU solver — it originally ran only under Sparse 1.3 and segfaulted under `.option klu` — so the line search now works under both linear solvers, with a residual-merit sequence numerically identical between them.*

[1] KLU is compiled in (SuiteSparse, statically linked) but is not the default in this build — the default direct solver is Sparse 1.3; KLU is selected with `.option klu`. The two agree on DC / AC / transient, and — since Enhancement-113 — on noise and single-ended pole-zero as well (the KLU adjoint solve was doing a non-transposed solve, silently wrong

on asymmetric matrices; now fixed), and — since Enhancement-114 — on DC/AC sensitivity (`.sens`) too. Still Sparse-only under KLU: balanced-output pole-zero and distortion (`.disto`, no KLU binding); KLU is also less robust on stiff transient edges. Full behavior, defaults, and a solver-by-solver sweep of the example suite: KLU vs. Sparse 1.3 solver notes.

Standard analyses (analog)

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Analyses	DC operating point / DC sweep	✓	✓
Analyses	Transient (`.tran`)	✓	✓
Analyses	AC small-signal (`.ac`)	✓	✓
Analyses	Noise, small-signal (`.noise`, onoise/inoise + integrated)	✓	✓
Analyses	Pole-zero (`.pz`)	✓	✓
Analyses	Transfer function (`.tf`)	✓	✓
Analyses	DC sensitivity (`.sens`)	✓	✓
Analyses	Distortion (`.disto`)	✓	✓
Analyses	Measurement / post-processing (`.meas`)	✓	✓

RF / periodic steady-state suite

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
RF	S-parameter analysis + noise figure (`.sp`)	✓	✓
RF	Touchstone (`.sNp`) import / export	✓	✓
RF	Periodic steady state (PSS)	⚠	✓
RF	Harmonic Balance (HB)	×	✓
RF	Periodic / phase noise (Pnoise)	×	✓
RF	Periodic AC (PAC, conversion gain)	×	✓
RF	Periodic transfer function (PXF)	×	✓
RF	Periodic S-parameters (PSP)	×	✓
RF	Quasi-periodic / multi-tone (QPSS / QPAC)	×	✓
RF	Envelope following	×	✓

PSS is ⚠ present but a brute-force shooting method, flagged experimental, and fragile on some circuits. HB exists only as a `WITH_HB` stub that returns "unsupported".

Performance & scale

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Performance	Multithreaded device-model evaluation (OpenMP)	✓	✓
Performance	Element bypass / latency exploitation	⚠	✓
Performance	Fast-SPICE hierarchical / isomorphic engine	×	✓
Performance	Distributed (MPI) / cloud partitioning	×	✓
Performance	Handles 10^6–10^8-node post-layout netlists	×	✓

Statistical / variability / yield

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Statistical	Monte Carlo	⚠	✓
Statistical	Native process/mismatch modeling + correlations	⚠	✓
Statistical	Low-discrepancy sampling (Sobol / Latin-hypercube)	×	✓
Statistical	High-sigma methods (importance sampling, worst-case distance)	×	✓
Statistical	Corner + MC + yield estimation flow	⚠	✓

Monte Carlo is ⚠ works, but script-driven (`alter` + `sgauss`, with the deterministic-seed RNG from Enhancement-10/66) rather than a native statistical block with sampling controls.

Reliability / aging

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Reliability	Device aging (HCI / NBTI / TDDB)	×	✓
Reliability	Stress → degrade → re-simulate (fresh/aged) flow	×	✓
Reliability	Electromigration + IR-drop (EMIR)	×	✓

Post-layout / parasitics

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Post-layout	Flat parasitic (RC) netlist simulation	✓	✓
Post-layout	RC reduction / model-order reduction	×	✓
Post-layout	n-port (S/Y/Z) extracted-block import	✓	✓

Behavioral / mixed-signal / AMS

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Modeling	Verilog-A (analog, LRM Annex C) via OSDI	✓	✓
Modeling	XSPICE code models + event-driven digital	✓	✓
Modeling	Verilog-AMS mixed-signal (connect modules)	×	✓
Modeling	Real-number modeling (wreal / RNM)	×	✓
Modeling	VHDL-AMS	×	✓

Interfaces & infrastructure

Category	Feature	ngspice	Spectre
Interface	Shared-library / programmatic API	✓	✓
Interface	Python bindings	✓	✓
Infrastructure	Built-in optimizer	×	✓
Infrastructure	Checkpoint / restart of long runs	⚠	✓

Where to invest (given the Verilog-A/OSDI side is done)

The realistic, winnable identity for this project is the open-source, OSDI/Verilog-A-native simulator with a real RF-noise and statistical story — not out-engineering 25 years of commercial fast-SPICE/parallel work. Ranked by leverage on the existing strength × differentiation × tractability:

1. RF periodic small-signal suite — Pnoise → PAC → PXF, on a hardened PSS. The device/OSDI side already supplies what these need (noise-source topology, operating-point- and frequency-dependent `load_noise`, periodic Jacobians); the work is the analysis engines. Genuinely novel in open source.
2. Convergence robustness — coordinated accuracy presets (`errpreset`) landed in Enhancement-110; the remaining piece is pseudo-transient / dynamic-gmin homotopy. Unglamorous but makes every analysis usable on real circuits; self-contained in the ngspice core.
3. High-sigma statistical sampling — high industrial value (yield / SRAM), moderate difficulty, leans on the deterministic-seed RNG already in place.

Explicitly lower priority: fast-SPICE parallelism and aging/EMIR — enormous efforts that don't leverage what makes this project distinctive.